CHRIS DAVIS



Panama City, Panama | +507 62774299 |
teacherslens@gmail.com |
teacherslens.com · linkedin.com/in/chris-davis-687b1b139
English (native) | Spanish (fluent)

PROFILE

Panama City–based international educator and curriculum designer with 25 years across elementary and middle school, EAL, library media, and educational technology. Authored three criteria of the ACS WASC Initial Visit School Report submitted for a K–8 school's successful advancement to candidacy for accreditation. Produced the largest MAP growth in a 1,700-student school's elementary division three years running, then wrote the position the school created to extend that practice across the division. Has led elementary literacy reform twice, twenty years apart; moved a middle school cohort to or above grade level in reading and mathematics; developed and supervised teaching staff through hiring, training, formal observation, and five years of job-embedded coaching cycles; and managed departmental budgets, procurement, and a learning-space build funded by six figures in corporate partnership. PYP-trained, M.A. in Elementary Education, certified in Elementary Education and ESL (Texas), PTC International School Leadership coursework in progress.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Teacher, Curriculum Designer, and Experiential Learning Coordinator
Manglares Discovery School — Panama | 2023–2026 (curriculum consulting ongoing)

Built the academic program for second grade and for the middle school at a 65-student K–8 school with no curriculum budget, using entirely open-source and free-tier resources; elements were adopted by other grade levels.

- Authored three criteria of the ACS WASC Initial Visit School Report — Equity and Access to Curriculum (B2), Student Engagement in Challenging and Relevant Learning Experiences (C1), and Student-Centered Instruction (C2) — supporting the school's successful advancement to candidacy for accreditation.
- Moved every continuously enrolled middle school student to or above grade level in reading and mathematics, from starting points ranging from half a grade to three grade levels below, with several students finishing well beyond grade level. Students entering mid-year are excluded from this cohort.
- Designed the full curriculum, scope, and sequence for second grade and for the middle school, built entirely from open-source content, and authored the companion textbook and student materials for each.
- Served as mentor teacher and assessor for a Moreland University teacher-certification candidate through her clinical practice (January–July 2025), conducting formal classroom observations and completing the evaluation documentation required for her certification.

- Selected and hired two paraprofessional support staff — reviewing applications, interviewing, and making the appointment — then designed and delivered their training for one-to-one and cluster support, and trained additional support teachers assigned to individual students.
- Designed an AI-supported translanguaging method for a Hebrew-speaking student, enabling him to work with full class texts rather than simplified substitutes. Daily, largely student-run, and multimodal — AI-generated infographics and graphic retellings — with scaffolds mapped to all five pillars of literacy. He drafted in Hebrew, transcribed, and interviewed peers and teachers in English, choosing his language over time and eventually moving to English; the method doubled as a running record.
- Designed and implemented a multi-leveled reading and writing intervention program spanning K–8 reading levels, with differentiated entry points, progress monitoring, and scaffolded supports for a wide range of student levels.
- Established schoolwide vertical alignment of Words Their Way phonics instruction across all grade levels, creating consistent progression and shared assessment practices between teachers.
- Initiated and rolled out a schoolwide Zearn Math program, including teacher onboarding, implementation support, and integration with existing instruction; established consistent schoolwide i-Ready administration protocols to protect test integrity and produce reliable assessment data.
- Taught second grade for one year in addition to curriculum and coordination responsibilities, and designed interdisciplinary elementary and middle school learning experiences integrating Common Core literacy and mathematics, NGSS science, C3 social studies inquiry, media arts, and environmental research.
- Led structured reading and writing instruction through workshop models, Socratic discussion, nonfiction research, oral presentation, and a scaffolded drafting, revision, editing, and publication process.
- Developed sustained student projects and public exhibitions using design-thinking cycles, including *This I Believe* essays, films, animation, photography, projection-mapped installations, laser-cut mathematical forms, and multimedia galleries.
- Created place-based environmental investigations focused on mangrove ecosystems, watersheds, biodiversity, and changing landscapes on Panama's Azuero Peninsula.
- Built collaborative, noncompetitive learning spaces using visual thinking, movement, dialogue, hands-on materials, creative expression, restorative practices, and differentiated supports for diverse learners.

Fourth Grade Teacher
International School of Panama — Panama City, Panama | 2022

- Designed differentiated fourth-grade units using Understanding by Design backward planning and inquiry-based instruction.
- Integrated STEM, design, and embodied mathematics through Sphero robotics geometry labs, Turtle Art block coding, Zearn/Singapore Math, sketchnotes, participatory theater, and responsive curriculum design.
- Facilitated literacy instruction through Socratic circles, collaborative inquiry, and multimodal learning experiences.

Library Media Literacy Teacher
Khartoum International Community School — Khartoum, Sudan | 2020–2021

- Managed Primary and Junior Library collections, cataloguing, purchasing, and the integration of Infant and Primary collections.
- Taught Pre-K through Year 6 media literacy, information literacy, digital citizenship, and computational literacy within the PYP framework.
- Designed reprogrammable learning spaces, coordinated Book Week, facilitated professional-development webinars, and supported collaborative student interviews with artists. Reprogrammable Spaces at KICS: video one · video two
- Held and managed the Early Years and Elementary library budget, directing collection development and acquisitions, and coordinated purchasing with the Middle Years and High School library.

Co-Founder, Producer and Learning-Space Researcher
Journeys in Podcasting — Bogotá, Colombia | 2016–2020

- Co-founded with two colleagues as practitioner research for the elementary project cycles at Colegio Nueva Granada — a way of sourcing what each project needed, which grew into a standing series.
- Produced 95+ episodes of a research-based series, conducting international interviews in maker spaces, hacker spaces, Reggio Emilia schools, laboratory learning sites, and innovative educational environments.
- Led workshops and consulting related to learning-space design, creative learning, inquiry, and experiential curriculum development.

Grade 3 Teacher
Colegio Nueva Granada — Bogotá, Colombia | 2008–2011

- Produced the largest MAP growth in the elementary division three years running at a 1,700-student K–12 school, with no other class close.
- Certified as a Restorative Practices trainer by the International Institute for Restorative Practices (Introduction to Restorative Practices / Using Circles Effectively — Training of Trainers, 2009), then led workshops for teachers and parents across the school community.

Tech Innovation Project Coordinator
Colegio Nueva Granada — Bogotá, Colombia | 2011–2016

- Wrote the position description for the role the school created to extend those classroom results across the division, then revised it annually with leadership so the role stayed aligned to the three school initiatives running that year.
- Ran a four-to-six-week co-creation cycle with pairs of teachers across upper elementary — designing interdisciplinary projects that culminated in Spotlight presentations to students, staff, and parents — working through all 18 homeroom teachers and drawing in art, music, library, and specialists from beyond the school as each project required.
- Documented every cycle as a video documentary displayed continuously on two large screens in the elementary hallway until the next cycle replaced it, creating a standing public record of student learning grounded in Project Zero's Making Learning Visible.

- Built a cross-divisional, in-house research channel — interviewing principals, coaches, teachers and specialists from elementary, middle and high school on whatever topic a current project required, so that expertise anywhere on campus could reach the classroom that needed it.
- Consulted with middle and high school on the use of the Global Learning Studio, through standing committee work and open cross-divisional communication.
- Managed technology purchasing for upper elementary.
- Designed the evidence and media template system for the school's SACS accreditation report at a 1,700-student K–12 institution, mapping standards to supporting artifacts and validating evidence submitted by every self-study committee.

Global Learning Studio — research, proposal, and build

- Conducted field research on immersive and active learning environments, including a study visit to the Hunt Library at NC State (Raleigh) to examine its projection-immersion spaces.
- Presented findings to the school Director, formed and led a cross-departmental committee, and secured approval to design and build a Global Learning Studio featuring blended laser projection onto a single continuous screen.
- Partnered with Sonic Design on projection and video systems integration; **secured over $100,000 USD in donated technology and furnishings from Steelcase and Samsung** after piloting a flexible-seating prototype that drew Steelcase's interest. Project profile — Sonic Design
- Managed recurring project cycles, critical events, and public demonstrations of student learning within the new space.
- The studio remains in daily use and continues to serve as the school's flagship learning space nearly a decade later.

Elementary Classroom Teacher
Colegio Karl C. Parrish — Barranquilla, Colombia | 2005–2008

- Taught Grade 3 using Project Zero's Spectrum approach to project-based learning, developing interdisciplinary projects built around students' varied entry points and strengths.
- Launched a student-and-teacher podcast broadcasting to parents and the wider Barranquilla community — student-produced audio for an authentic external audience, predating classroom podcasting as common practice.
- Directed large-scale stage productions centered on literacy development, using rap, song, and performance as vehicles for oral language, fluency, and text comprehension.
- Founded and led a student folkloric drumming ensemble that performed at every recess, building a daily music practice into the life of the school.
- Implemented Junior Great Books reading projects culminating in student symposia and Socratic discussion; sessions were filmed, transcribed, and published for parents and the community.
- Partnered with the Art teacher to create a student gallery, interviewing each student about their portfolio and printing the transcribed reflections alongside their artwork.

Sabbatical — Documentary Motorcycle Expedition, South America | 2004–2005

- Rode South America by motorcycle with a fellow international educator, prioritizing unpaved routes and rural crossings over highways.
- Photo-documented the journey and produced a live travel website publishing dispatches from the road.
- Organized “A Day at Work” experiences with local hosts in communities along the route, working alongside people in their trades and documenting the exchange.

Elementary Classroom Teacher
Colegio Karl C. Parrish — Barranquilla, Colombia | 2001–2004

- Instigated reform of the elementary literacy program, moving the school from a traditional basal-reader and daily-drill model to a balanced literacy approach with a strong phonics foundation, drawing on Patricia Cunningham’s resources.
- Piloted and secured adoption of the Oregon Math Center approach across the elementary years.
- Developed Project Zero–based interdisciplinary projects in close collaboration with the school’s Reggio Emilia atelier.
- Created a bookmaking project documenting student writing alongside transcriptions of videotaped Socratic discussions; the finished books were catalogued in the school library and available for all students to check out.
- Innovated music and literacy routines using call-and-response rap and song to build fluency, phrasing, and oral language.
- Taught Grade 2, with arts integration and student-voice documentation embedded throughout.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

ESL Coordinator / Middle School ESL Teacher, Academia Cotopaxi, Quito, Ecuador | 2000–2001

Elementary Classroom Teacher, Cochabamba Cooperative School, Cochabamba, Bolivia | 1999–2000

ESL Teacher, Morgan Academy Arts Magnet School, Galveston, Texas | 1997–1999

Teacher Trainer / High School ESL Teacher, WorldTeach at Harvard University, Łańcut and Rzeszów, Poland | 1991–1993

EDUCATION

M.A. in Elementary Education — University of Alabama, Bogotá, Colombia Specialized in interdisciplinary learning, progressive redesign of learning environments, and the development of engaging, contextualized learning experiences.

ESL / Elementary Teacher Certification Program — University of St. Thomas with Region IV, Houston, Texas Joint certification in ESL and Elementary Education; Lifetime Texas ESL certification. Focused on Multiple Intelligences approaches to language learning and differentiated instruction.

B.A. in International Studies — Southwestern University, Georgetown, Texas Liberal arts degree focused on international history and literature, with additional emphasis in photography and classical guitar.

Graduate Coursework in Post-Soviet Studies — University of Texas, Austin, Texas Two years of graduate study in regional history, politics, and culture, following two years teaching in Poland.

CORE PROFESSIONAL SKILLS

Curriculum and Instruction — Literacy Intervention • Balanced Literacy • Writers Workshop • Socratic Seminar • Project-Based Learning • Interdisciplinary Curriculum Design • Differentiated Instruction • English Language Learner Support • Translanguaging • Inquiry-Based Learning • Pre-Service Teacher Mentoring and Assessment • Staff Selection and Supervision • Accreditation Self-Study and Evidence Documentation

Media, Information, and Technology Literacy — Media Literacy • Digital Citizenship • Library Management • AI in Education • Maker Literacy Labs • Documentary Production • Podcast Production • Projection Mapping

Learning Environments and School Culture — Learning Space Design • Reggio Emilia-Inspired Documentation • Active Learning Spaces • Student Voice • Family Communication • Restorative Practices • Professional Development Facilitation

MEDIA PROJECTS

Journeys in Podcasting — Creator and producer of a 95-episode educator-focused podcast exploring inquiry-based learning, constructivism, experiential education, learning-space design, and innovative school models. Spotify · Soundcloud

Published Writing — *Reflection, Conversation, and Socratic Spaces*, Edutopia (George Lucas Educational Foundation), 2014.

Teacher's Lens Blog — Reflections on the relationship among experience, research, belief, agency, and the development of "live hypotheses" in education. Substack · Blogspot

Classroom Family Communication — Class blogs documenting daily learning, student work, and inquiry projects for parent communities. Our Class in Motion · Fourth Grade Blog

KICS TV — Co-created a crowdsourced school video platform during the COVID-19 pandemic, sustaining community, student voice, and family connection while the school was dispersed. Khartoum International Community School. KICS TV, Episode 1

First Six Weeks of School — A daily video series documenting the opening weeks of the school year at Manglares, building community as students and families settled in. Watch the series

TECHNOLOGY AND MEDIA TOOLKIT

ChatGPT • Gemini • Claude • Oliver Softlink LMS • Google Workspace for Education • Adobe Creative Suite (Photoshop, Premiere Pro, Lightroom, Audition) • GarageBand • Logic Pro X • Projection Mapping • iPad Media Production • Explain Everything • DSLR Photography • Video Documentary • Audio Recording • Screencasting • Drone Filming

SELECTED PROFESSIONAL TRAINING

Making the PYP Happen • IIRP Restorative Practices: Training of Trainers (2009) • Constructing Modern Knowledge • NYU ITP Camp • Reggio Emilia: Children and Nature • NOTOSH / LUMA Institute: Design Thinking for Educators • How to Research and Write Using Generative AI Tools • MIT Scratch Game Design

In progress — Leading Recruitment in International Schools, The Principals' Training Center for International School Leadership (September–November 2026); half credit toward the PTC Certificate in International School Leadership.

Facilitated professional development on restorative practices and circles, design thinking, active learning spaces, remote teaching, participatory theater and transmedia storytelling, and student media production.

EXTRACURRICULAR CONTRIBUTIONS

Classical guitar and hand percussion (music ECAs) • Photography and yearbook • Video and documentary production • Podcasting and student media • Running and swimming